

NOUN → ADJECTIVE

blood *bloody**beef* *beefy**bush* *bushy**ice* *icy*

?

grotty

So some time around the early 70s, speakers made the following entirely reasonable inference: if adjectives like *bloody* and *beefy* are related to the nouns *blood* and *beef*, then what could the noun corresponding to the adjective *grotty* be, except . . .



grot

grotty

And thus the noun 'grot' was born, meaning something like 'dirt' or 'rubbish'. This new coinage seems to have been popularized by a BBC television series of the late 70s, in which a character called Reginald Perrin makes a fortune from a chain of shops called 'Grot' that sell goods with 'terminally built-in obsolescence'.

Linguists call the type of analogy that produced 'grot' 'back formation', because in terms of historical accuracy, it actually went backwards. Unlike 'bloody', for instance, which indeed had the noun 'blood' as its forebear, 'grotty' began life as an abbreviation of another adjective, 'grotesque'. (Of course, if one were to trace the ancestry of 'grotty' itself much further back, it would emerge that the adjective from which it sprang, 'grotesque' ultimately does go back to a noun, but a different one, *grotto*, meaning 'cave'. As far as 'grot' is concerned, however, this early history is beside the point.) From a historical perspective, then, 'grotty' did not owe its existence to a noun 'grot', and the analogy that produced 'grot' was incorrect. But the speakers who made this inference couldn't give two hoots about the historical perspective. All they did was recognize a pattern (NOUN + *y* → ADJECTIVE) and apply it, albeit in reverse, to a new adjective that seemed to fit, thereby making the adjective conform to the regular pattern.

Such an analogical back formation may seem rather strained at first, but inferences of this kind are extremely common, and the history of English

provides dozens of other examples. The noun 'greed', for instance, emerged in the seventeenth century through exactly the same type of back formation, when speakers 'incorrectly' applied the pattern $\text{NOUN} + y \rightarrow \text{ADJECTIVE}$ to the adjective 'greedy', which did not have a noun counterpart at the time. New verbs can also emerge through such analogical innovations, when common patterns are applied in reverse. The pattern $\text{VERB} + \text{or} \rightarrow \text{NOUN}$, for instance, creates many nouns from verbs: 'visit-or' (from 'visit'), 'govern-or' (from 'govern'), 'vend-or', 'survey-or', and so on. But in the eighteenth century the pattern was incorrectly applied backwards to the nouns 'editor' and 'legislator' (both of which came from Latin nouns), to create the new verbs 'edit' and 'legislate'. Who knows, perhaps at some stage in the future, similar back formations will make writers 'auth books', medics 'doct patients', and ships 'anch in harbour'.

Other back formations produced the English singular nouns 'cherry' and 'pea'. 'Cherry' comes from Old Northern French *cherise*, a word which happened to end with an *s* sound although it wasn't plural – just like 'cheese' today. In the fourteenth century, some speakers falsely assumed that *cherise* was an instance of the common pattern $\text{NOUN} + s \rightarrow \text{PLURAL}$, so they applied this pattern in reverse, and produced the singular form 'cherry'. This must initially have sounded just as 'wrong' to educated speakers as 'one chee' would to us today. 'Pea' had a similar history, as it derives from an earlier singular 'pease' (which still survives in the set phrase 'pease-pudding'). But around 1600 'pease' was misinterpreted as a plural, and so 'pea' emerged as the singular form. Such back formations continue even now, as illustrated by the child who was overheard complaining that there was only 'one Weetabick' left in the packet.

All this goes to show that the course of change is determined not only by 'blind' effort-saving forces, heedless of all but the phonetic environment, but also by the craving for order of generation upon generation of speakers. The mind is constantly on the lookout for any signs of recurrent patterns, because the more regularity it can recognize, the easier its task of coping with the mass of linguistic detail it has to absorb. When the mind picks out a recurrent pattern, it naturally tries to extend it to whatever seems to fit. And since speakers rarely know (nor care) about earlier stages of the language, they can happily extend a pattern even to those forms which never had anything to do with it in the first place.

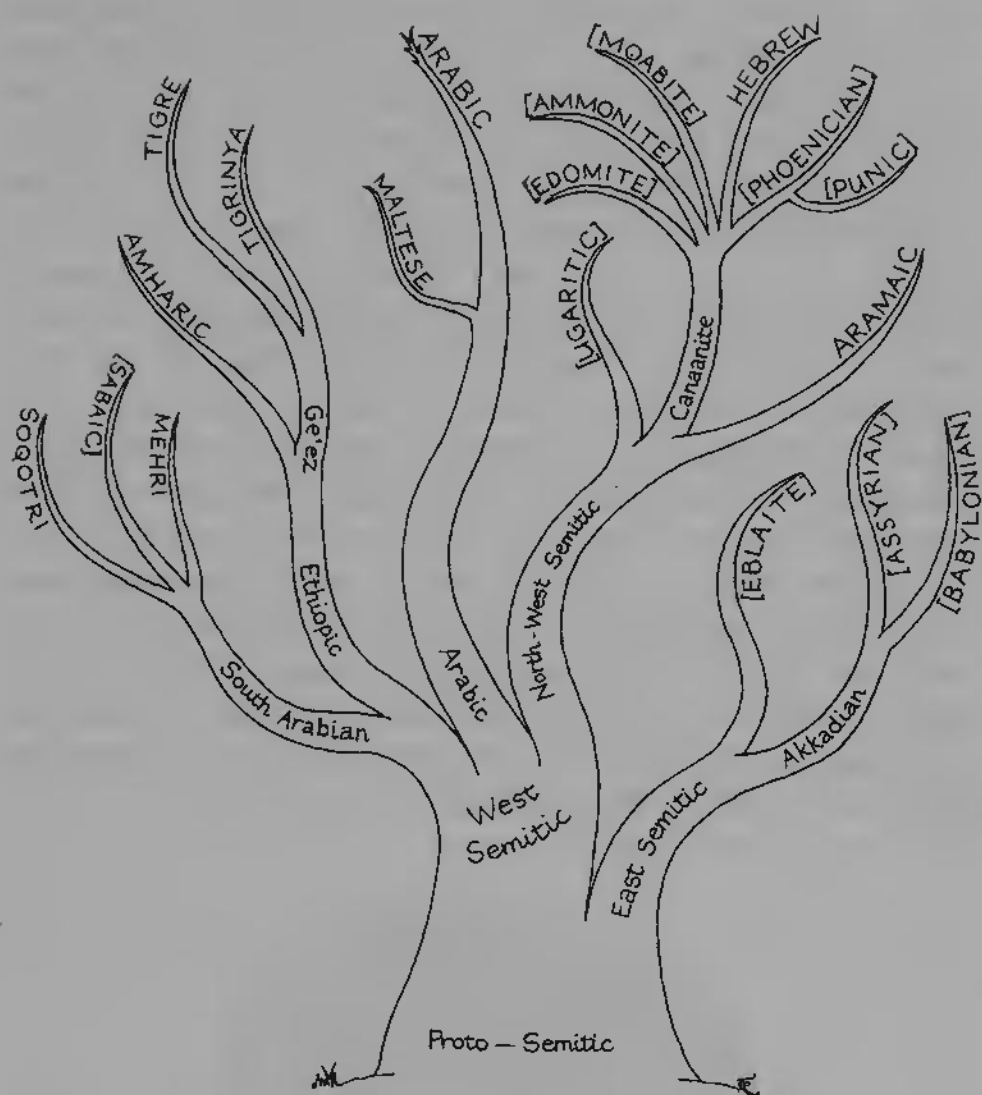
The birth of 'grot' was the outcome of one extremely simple sequence

of effort-saving and analogy: a hip abbreviation followed by an extension of the pattern (NOUN+ γ $\rightarrow$ ADJECTIVE) to the 'inappropriate' 'grotty'. And it may require a considerable stretch of the imagination to believe that such a simple cycle could have anything to do with the creation of abstract linguistic designs, let alone highly sophisticated ones. And yet the following pages will argue that a series of similar cycles is capable of great feats. In particular, the interplay between erosion and analogy is what must have been behind the development of the Semitic verbal system.



Before delving into the verbal system of the Semitic languages, a few words about their cultural history are in place. The Semitic languages have a written history spanning more than 4,500 years. The original heartland of the Semites seems to have been the Arabian peninsula, whence Semitic-speaking tribes spread in different waves into large areas of the Near East and North Africa (see map on pages viii–ix).

The oldest known member of the language family is **Akkadian**, which is attested from around 2500 BC, and is thus one of the earliest written languages of all. (Only Sumerian and Ancient Egyptian can beat that record.) Akkadian was spoken in Mesopotamia, the land 'between the rivers', the Euphrates and the Tigris, in an area roughly corresponding to today's Iraq. The name of the language derives from the city of Akkade, founded in the twenty-third century BC as the imperial capital of the first 'world conqueror', King Sargon. Later on, after 2000 BC, Akkadian diverged into two main varieties, Babylonian in the south of Mesopotamia and Assyrian in the north, both of which were to become the languages of powerful empires. Speakers of Akkadian (both Babylonian and Assyrian) dominated the political and cultural horizon of the Near East up until the sixth century BC. Their political star may have waxed and waned, but for a good part of 2,000 years, Mesopotamian emperors, from Sargon in the third millennium BC to Sennacherib and Nebuchadnezzar in the first, would lay claim to the title 'King of the Universe', ruling over the 'the four corners (of the earth)'. More stable than the power of the sword, however, was the cultural hegemony of Mesopotamia over the whole region. The Akkadian language shaped the dominant canon for much of the Near East in religion, the arts, science and law, and was used as a *lingua franca*, the means of diplomatic correspondence. Petty governors of provincial



Family tree of the Semitic languages

Canaanite outposts, mighty Anatolian kings, and even Egyptian Pharaohs wrote to one another in Akkadian. Languages across the Near East also borrowed many scientific and cultural terms from Akkadian, a few of which may even be recognized by English speakers today. The Jewish expression *mazel tov* 'good luck', for example, is based on the Hebrew word *mazal* 'luck', which was borrowed from the Akkadian astrological term *mazzaltu* 'position (of a star)'.

But after nearly 2,000 years of cultural supremacy, the political demise of Assyria and Babylon in the sixth century BC ushered in an age of rapid

decline, and within a few centuries both the Akkadian language and its writing system fell into oblivion. Hundreds of thousands of clay tablets, the product of two thousand years of civilization, lay forgotten in the desert sands for two more millennia, to be rediscovered and deciphered only in the nineteenth century. Since then, an almost unbelievable wealth of texts has been recovered from the soil of Iraq and neighbouring countries, and has opened up a unique perspective on one of history's greatest civilizations. The texts encompass almost every imaginable genre, from poetry (such as the Epic of Gilgamesh) to legal documents (such as the Code of Hammurabi), not to mention religious incantations, histories, royal inscriptions of heroic deeds, diplomatic correspondence, monolingual and multilingual dictionaries, mathematical and astronomical texts, medical treatises, and a seemingly endless quantity of administrative documents. One of the most revealing genres, however, is that of ordinary private letters dealing with quotidian subjects, from commercial haggling to domestic disputes. Here, as one example, is perhaps the first ever recorded endeavour to calm family tensions. This short missive was written in the twenty-third century BC, and shows that on some issues, little has changed in more than 4,000 years:



A letter from the Old Akkadian period,
twenty-third century BC